Determiners and Subject–Verb Agreement

The big idea

Determiners are small words placed before a noun to tell us *which*, *whose* or *how much/many*. **Subject–verb agreement** means the verb must match its subject in **number** (singular/plural) and **person**. Both topics appear in CBSE gap-filling, editing and omission tasks, so learning the rules saves easy marks.

Part A: Determiners

DEFINITION

A **determiner** comes before a noun (and before any adjective) and limits or specifies it: **the** red car, **my** book, **some** water, **every** student.

Kinds of determiners

Kind	Examples
Articles	a, an, the
Demonstratives	this, that, these, those
Possessives	my, your, his, her, its, our, their
Quantifiers	some, any, much, many, few, a few, little, a little, several, enough, all, both
Numbers	one, two, first, second
Distributives	each, every, either, neither

Kind	Examples
Interrogatives	which, what, whose

Articles

- **a** before a consonant **sound**: a boy, a **u**niversity (yoo-), a **o**ne-rupee coin (wun-).
- **an** before a vowel **sound**: an apple, an **h**our, an **h**onest man, an **M**LA (em-).
- **the** for something specific or already mentioned, unique things (**the** sun), superlatives (**the** best), rivers, oceans, mountain ranges (**the** Ganga, **the** Himalayas), and musical instruments (play **the** flute).
- **No article** before names of languages, subjects, meals and most proper nouns: She speaks Hindi. We had lunch.

SOUND, NOT SPELLING

"a honest man" is wrong; "h" is silent, so the sound is a vowel: **an** honest man. "an European" is wrong: Eu = "yoo", so **a** European.

Quantifiers

- **much / little / a little** with **uncountable** nouns: much milk, little time.
- **many / few / a few** with **countable** plurals: many books, a few friends.
- **few / little** = almost none (negative sense); **a few / a little** = some (positive sense).
- **some** in positive sentences and offers; **any** in negatives and questions: I have some money. Do you have any money?

FEW VS A FEW

Few students passed (very bad result). A few students passed (some did).

This, that, these, those

- **this/that** + singular; **these/those** + plural. This and these = near; that and those = far.

Part B: Subject–verb agreement

BASIC RULE

A **singular subject** takes a **singular verb**; a **plural subject** takes a **plural verb**. In the simple present, singular third-person verbs end in -s/-es: He **plays**. They **play**.

Important rules

1. **Two subjects joined by "and"** take a plural verb: Ram and Shyam **are** friends. But if they refer to one person/idea: Bread and butter **is** my breakfast. The poet and singer **has** come.
2. **Each, every, everyone, everybody, nobody, someone, either, neither** take a **singular** verb: Each of the boys **has** a pen. Everyone **is** present.
3. **Either…or / neither…nor / not only…but also**: the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject: Neither the teacher nor the students **were** late. Either the students or the teacher **is** coming.
4. **With, along with, as well as, together with, besides**: the verb agrees with the **first** subject: The captain, along with his players, **was** honoured.
5. **Collective nouns** (team, jury, family) take a singular verb when acting as one unit, plural when members act separately: The jury **has** given its verdict. The jury **were** divided in their opinions.
6. **Distances, money, time** as one amount take a singular verb: Ten kilometres **is** a long walk. Five hundred rupees **is** too much.
7. **Words that look plural but are singular**: news, mathematics, physics, economics, measles: The news **is** good.

8. **Always plural**: scissors, trousers, spectacles, cattle, police: The police **have** arrived. (But: A pair of scissors **is** on the table.)
9. **"One of" + plural noun** takes a singular verb: One of my friends **lives** in Delhi.
10. **"A number of"** = many → plural; **"The number of"** → singular: A number of students **were** absent. The number of students **is** fifty.
11. **"There is/There are"**: the verb agrees with the noun that follows: There **are** many books. There **is** a pen.
12. **Titles of books/films** take a singular verb: *Wings of Fire* **is** inspiring.

DON'T AGREE WITH THE NEAREST NOUN BY MISTAKE

"The box of chocolates **are** on the table" is wrong. The subject is **box** (singular): The box of chocolates **is** on the table.

EDITING TASKS

In an editing passage, first find the real subject of each verb (ignore phrases like "of the boys", "along with"), then check number and tense. Write answers as **incorrect word → correct word**.

Practice

Fill in: (a) ___ honest man (b) Neither of them ___ (is/are) ready. (c) The cattle ___ (is/are) grazing. (d) Mathematics ___ (is/are) my favourite subject. (e) ___ few students who came were rewarded (the/a).
Answers: (a) An (b) is (c) are (d) is (e) The

Quick recap

- Articles depend on sound; few/little are negative; much with uncountable, many with countable.
- Each/every/neither take singular verbs; either...or agrees with the nearer subject.

- "As well as/along with" agree with the first subject; "a number of" plural, "the number of" singular.

Practice questions

1. Choose the correct option: She waited for ___ hour.
   (a) a (b) an (c) the (d) no article
2. Choose the correct option: He is ___ European.
   (a) a (b) an (c) the (d) some
3. I have ___ friends, so I am never lonely.
   (a) few (b) little (c) much (d) a few
4. Each of the players ___ given a medal.
   (a) were (b) are (c) have been (d) was
5. Neither the teacher nor the students ___ present.
   (a) was (b) were (c) is (d) has been
6. The Prime Minister, along with his ministers, ___ visiting the flood-hit area.
   (a) is (b) are (c) were (d) have been
7. A number of tourists ___ visiting Kathmandu this week.
   (a) is (b) was (c) are (d) has
8. Which sentence is correct?
   (a) The news are very surprising. (b) Mathematics are difficult for him. (c) The police have arrested the thief. (d) The cattle is grazing in the field.
9. Edit the passage. Write the incorrect word and the correction: "Every students in the class have a library card. A honest effort are needed to read regularly."

Answers: 1. b 2. a 3. d 4. d 5. b 6. a 7. c 8. c 9. see notes